

How to Choose the Right Walker or Cane

A practical guide for families and caregivers

The wrong walking aid can be just as dangerous as no walking aid at all. This guide explains the different types of canes and walkers, who each is designed for, and what to look for when making a decision.

CANES

Standard single-tip cane

Best for: Mild balance issues, minor weakness on one side, or added confidence on uneven surfaces. Provides light support — not intended for significant weight-bearing. Used on the opposite side from the weak or injured leg.

Offset cane

Best for: Anyone who needs to put more weight through their cane. The curved neck positions the body weight directly over the tip, reducing wrist strain and providing more stability than a standard cane.

Quad cane (four-point base)

Best for: Significant one-sided weakness, stroke recovery, or anyone who needs a cane that stands on its own. Provides more stability than a single-tip cane but is slower to use and works best on flat surfaces.

WALKERS

Standard walker (no wheels)

Best for: Significant weakness in both legs, recovering from surgery, or anyone who needs maximum stability. Requires lifting and placing with each step — slower but very stable. Not ideal if the user has upper body weakness.

Two-wheel walker (front-wheeled walker)

Best for: Those who need stability but find the standard walker too slow or difficult to lift. Wheels on the front allow a more natural walking rhythm. Still requires some upper body strength to control.

Four-wheel walker / rollator

Best for: More independent walkers who need light support, balance confidence, and endurance. Includes brakes, a seat for resting, and often a basket. Not appropriate for those who need to heavily weight-bear through the walker.

Knee walker / knee scooter

Best for: Non-weight-bearing recovery from foot or ankle injury or surgery. The affected leg rests on a padded platform while the other leg propels. Not a general mobility aid.

GETTING THE HEIGHT RIGHT

An incorrectly fitted walking aid increases fall risk. Here's a quick guide:

- Stand upright with arms relaxed at your sides
- The top of the cane or walker handles should reach your wrist crease
- When gripping the handle, your elbow should bend at approximately 15-20 degrees
- If you're hunching over your walker, it's too low
- If your arms are nearly straight, it's too high
- Most walkers and canes are adjustable — always check the fit

WHEN TO SEE A PHYSICAL THERAPIST

A physical therapist should always be involved in selecting and fitting a walking aid, particularly after a fall, surgery, stroke, or if there's been a noticeable change in mobility. Using the wrong aid — or using the right aid incorrectly — can cause falls rather than prevent them.

Savoy Therapy can assess your loved one's specific needs and recommend the most appropriate walking aid. savoytherapy.com | 217-898-8393